

Poolside at Wayanad Wild

The monsoon drama is at its peak in the cloud forests of Wayanad. The scenic inner route via Chalakudy, Thrissur and Perinthalmanna climbs the Thamarassery Churam (ghat) up nine hairpin bends to the misty pass Lakkidi (2,300 ft), the gateway to Wayanad. In the past, local tribes were the custodians of the ghats and forests. The British were looking for a route to connect the lucrative coastal trade to Mysore. Around 1750, Karinthandan, a local Paniya chief living at the foothills of Lakkidi, disclosed a safe path to a British engineer, who killed him. The story goes that Karinthandan's spirit lurked along the stretch, haunting travellers and causing a slew of accidents until a puja was performed to pacify him, and his restless soul was chained to a tree.

Leaving our vehicle at the CGH parking lot near Chain Tree, we hopped into a jeep for a 4-km offroad ascent to Wayanad Wild. Deep in the rainforest, the wilderness camp is the perfect perch to experience the rains from the comfort of your balcony or trails in the vicinity. Music filled the air in the soft pitter-patter of raindrops, silvery leaves shimmering in the breeze and the constant sonata of frogs, cicadas, crickets and birdsong. The misty, dark woods are livened up by a flash of orange—is it a Black and Orange Flycatcher? Scarlet Minivet? No, it's the Malabar Trogon! The daily schedule of activities overseen by naturalist, photographer and author David Raju and his young team, keeps guests enthralled—a morning bird-watching trail, creek explorations, a 5-km hike to the nearby hillock in the afternoon, eco-talks in the evening and a night walk around the property to look for elusive frogs and reptiles.

Our nocturnal guide Daimler, a naturalist from Mumbai, was named by his uncle after the car—he has a cousin called Chrysler! In a short span of a few hundred metres lay a hidden world lurking in the shadows—Malabar Flying Frogs and Nilgiri Forest Lizard perched on branches, a Golden Backed Frog blending into the leaf litter, the riveting Green Vine Snake, a Malabar Pit Viper lying in wait motionless for unsuspecting prey, and an Ochlandra Reed Frog that lays eggs in the hollows of the Ochlandra reed bamboo. A battery of macro photographers in ponchos headed into the dark. Life for them was an endless cycle of Eat Sleep Herp Retreat. It started to drizzle…the croaks grew louder…another busy monsoon night unfolded in Kerala. ■